

How to undo another user's checkout in TFS?

As the resident TFS admin, on occasion I am asked to undo a checkout (usually a lock) that a user has on a certain file checked into source control.

How do you undo another user's checkout?

tfs tfs2010 tfs2012 tfs2008 tfs2013

edited Nov 1 '13 at 18:52

asked Nov 6 '09 at 21:18



brett rogers

4,117 6 21 37

6 Answers

There are at least 2 different ways to do this:

Command Line

There is a command-line utility called Tf.exe that comes with Team Explorer. Find the documentation [here](#). It can be accessed by launching a Visual Studio Command Prompt window. The syntax of the command is:

```
tf undo [/workspace:workspacename[;workspaceowner]]
[/server:servername] [/recursive] itemspec [/noprompt]
```

For one file

```
tf undo /workspace:workspacename;workspaceowner $/projectname/filename.cs
```

GUI

The second is via the GUI, but does not come standard - you have to install the [TFS Power Tools](#). See [here for details](#) on how to use this method.

Keep in mind that with either method you will need the appropriate rights. The permissions are called "Undo other users' changes" and "Unlock other users' changes". These permissions can be viewed by:

1. Right-clicking the desired project, folder, or file in Source Control Explorer
2. Select Properties
3. Select the Security tab
4. Select the appropriate user or group in the Users and Groups section at the top
5. View the "Permissions for [user/group]:" section at the bottom

Deleting the workspace

```
tf workspace /delete WorkspaceName;User
/server:http://server:8080/tfs/MyTeamCollection
```

edited Oct 6 '14 at 10:04



Kiquenet

5,662 24 91 159

answered Nov 6 '09 at 21:21



brett rogers

4,117 6 21 37

For me the command `tf undo /workspace:mydesk *.sdf` reports "No pending changes" but does not undo the check-out (lock) – [dumbledad](#) Oct 28 '12 at 16:04

I forgot the TFS server path before my `tf *.sdf itemspec`, I'd assumed it would work it out from the current directory. The command line you give works for me now. – [dumbledad](#) Oct 28 '12 at 16:14

- 1 Make sure you use quotes around paths with spaces, otherwise you might get message like: "No pending changes were found for \$/xxx" – [PeterX](#) Jan 14 '14 at 3:15

How do I find the workspace name? I see I can run: `tf workspaces /owner:[other user] /server:[server]`, I get a list of four workspaces the user has, but how would I know which workspace it is for the file? – [PeterX](#) Jan 14 '14 at 3:21

PeterX, you can see the workspace by navigating to the file in Visual Studio's Solution Explorer, right click the locked file and select Properties, then in the Status tab you have info about the workspace and user that locked the file – [Dante](#) Jul 7 '14 at 9:26

The easiest way I found is to use the free [TFS Sidekick application](#). It has an option to view and undo other user's checkout.

edited Jul 12 '13 at 17:25



[p.campbell](#)

59.5k 51 196 281

answered Nov 6 '09 at 21:21



[Marek Karbarz](#)

21.3k 5 41 68

1 +1; [attrice.info/cm/tfs](#) – [Christopher Klein](#) Nov 6 '09 at 21:53

5 It is below "Status Sidekick". Search, select files, undo. – [Wolf5](#) May 30 '14 at 11:28

If user has left the company then you have to know the Active Directory username (which is not always same as user's firstname and/or lastname). My company assigns numbered usernames so I had to look up the retired user before I could search for him in VS or in the Status TFS Sidekick.
– [Zephan Schroeder](#) Nov 4 '14 at 22:16

This worked amazingly. so much easier than trying to figure out workspace names and such using the command line tool. – [Bo Flexson](#) Jul 14 '15 at 20:41

I just had this problem myself and found an easier way to clean up old workspaces.

- 1) In visual studio, open source control explorer.
- 2) From the 'Workspace' dropdown select 'Workspaces...'
- 3) A dialog will appear showing the workspaces on your current PC. Select 'Show remote workspaces'
- 4) You will now also see workspaces from your previous PC (as long as they are from the same user account). Select the old workspace(s) and click 'Remove'. This should delete the old workspace from from TFS along with any persisting checkouts.

I'm sure Arne has found a solution but I hope this helps others who google the issue.

answered Feb 25 '14 at 11:43



[saeid mohammad hashem](#)

445 1 6 7

This worked for me (VS2012 / TFS 2010) – [Gordon Slysz](#) Mar 10 '14 at 17:22

4 This works well if you are the workspace owner, especially for cleaning up your current list of workspaces. Not so good for deleting other user's workspaces or checkout locks :-).
– [Zephan Schroeder](#) Nov 4 '14 at 22:13

Agreed. This works well for deleting your own checkout locks from another PC. – [Chris](#) Oct 15 '16 at 16:42

Right, but the question is specific to unlock files that are checked out to a DIFFERENT user.
– [BrainSlugs83](#) Feb 8 at 21:05

Select your file in TFS sidekick, then above the list, you have a "undo pending Change". Click on that and the change will be undone :) The icon is similar to the "Undo" icon in MS word Get TFS sidekicks from <http://www.attrice.info/cm/tfs/index.htm>

answered Mar 26 '12 at 11:08



[Maryam](#)

81 1 1

Simplest Tool to use. Really helped me undo a change at the solution level that a ex-worker had checked out – [Vishnoo Rath](#) Mar 1 '13 at 10:08

As a TFS admin, I have run into the issue of developers checking out files in their workspace

and leaving it that way. When I try to archive/move the branches to other folders, TFS doesn't let me and wants to undo all those checkouts. As mentioned in the above answer, the TFS Power tools helps you to see and undo others checkout from within Visual studio. But it can only perform the UNDO operation for one user at a time. So that means if 50 developers have each checked out 1 file, then I will have to press UNDO button 50 times. So I wrote a powershell script which queries the TFS to find the list of users/files checked out, then it loops through and UNDO all the files to those users. Here is the URL to the GIT repository. Please let me know if you face any issues.

[GIT Repository](#)

deleted by [Flexo](#) ♦ Feb 28 '15 at 23:00

answered Feb 28 '15 at 5:56



[Isaiah4110](#)

6,280 17 32

Is there a way to leverage the tf undo command from the TFS SDK ? (This is so that I can integrate some functionality in one of the IDE integrations)

deleted by [Gumbo](#) Mar 30 '11 at 8:55

answered Oct 3 '10 at 22:29



[Looneystar](#)

82 11

You should post this as a separate question, not an answer to this question. – [brett rogers](#) Jan 20 '11 at 19:13
